

How to Spot AI-Written Text

This serves as a guide to help detect AI-generated text

Highlighted **like this** = the specific words or phrases that are similar to AI-generated text.

Every clue we will learn in this document, which will help us in flagging a text as AI-generated, also appears in ordinary human writing. What tells us that AI wrote a specific piece of text is multiple of these clues stacked in one passage. We have to try to identify multiple such clues/signs in a passage and shouldn't flag it as AI by looking at a single clue/sign.

1 Words & phrases used by AI

Vocabulary is one of the most important signals for detecting AI writing. AI often uses the same set of words and filler phrases, regardless of the underlying topic.

1a · The most frequently used vocabulary

AI overuses a set of common formal words. Observing one word in a paragraph/passage might not tell us that it's AI-generated, but seeing many of them in a paragraph/passage is a big hint that it's AI-generated text.

Most commonly used words by AI: delve, tapestry, testament, underscore, showcase, intricate, pivotal, crucial, vibrant, realm, landscape, foster, nuanced, multifaceted, seamless, robust, leverage, harness, navigate, boasts, elevate, unlock, embark, meticulous, myriad

AI-STYLE

Our city's markets are a vibrant tapestry of culture that underscores its rich heritage, offering visitors a seamless and multifaceted experience that is a true testament to community spirit.

HUMAN-STYLE

People from different localities, representing diverse cultures, come to our local market, held every Saturday. The whole place is filled with people chatting about recent events in their respective neighbourhoods.

QUICK CHECK

We should identify fancy-looking words, such as those mentioned in the above list. If we find a lot of these words in a paragraph/passage, especially when it's not about something very special, it can be a strong sign of AI-generated text.

1b · Common openers, transitions & filler

AI often uses ready-made phrases that do not convey useful information. They are like words that people use to clear their throats before speaking.

We can look for these phrases: “It’s important to note that...”, “In today’s fast-paced world...”, “When it comes to...”, “Needless to say...”, “That being said...”, “plays a significant/vital role”, “at the end of the day”, “a wide range of”, “whether you’re a ... or a ...”

AI-STYLE

In today’s fast-paced world, sleep is more important than ever. It’s important to note that rest plays a vital role in health, whether you’re a student or a busy professional.

HUMAN-STYLE

Whenever I visit my family doctor regarding any ailment, he doesn’t forget to emphasize the importance of sleep in one’s health. He always shares that he feels quite active during the day, whenever he gets a good sleep the previous night.

1c · AI uses Promotional/Marketing-style language

When we ask AI to write about something, it often produces text that will likely appear in a travel guide or an advertisement: everything is stunning, breathtaking, and world-class. It often feels like we are reading an advertisement about something.

Look for these WORDS: **breathtaking, stunning, nestled, must-visit, hidden gem, rich cultural heritage, vibrant, iconic, world-class, unforgettable, picturesque, boasts a..., stands as a...**

AI-STYLE

Nestled in the hills, this hidden gem boasts breathtaking views and a rich cultural heritage, making it a must-visit destination for any traveller.

HUMAN-STYLE

The Park on top of the hill near my home attracts many tourists every day. It’s also quite famous among locals as a weekend destination for its beautiful view of the town.

2 Rhythm & sentence structure

Another clue to detect AI writing is *sentence structure and rhythm*, i.e., how sentences are built and paced. AI writing has a smooth, even, and slightly mechanical rhythm. Human writing is usually less regular, with more variation and unevenness.

2a · AI tends to produce uniform sentences

AI tends to produce sentences of similar length and grammatical shape, one after another, with few very short or very long ones. Humans usually vary their sentences more, i.e., a long sentence may be followed by a very short one or even a sentence fragment. This makes the human writing feel more natural and gives emphasis or punch (means to make a particular idea stand out and feel stronger).

AI-STYLE

The team worked hard all season. They trained every morning. They studied their opponents closely. They believed in their goal. Their effort paid off in the end.

— five sentences with similar length and rhythm.

HUMAN-STYLE

The Players have been preparing rigorously for the upcoming frisbee tournament despite encountering multiple issues, including weather and the unavailability of proper training equipment. Hope their efforts pay off.

QUICK CHECK

Read one paragraph aloud. If every sentence has the same beat and the same length, that could be a sign of AI-generated text.

2b · AI often outputs Groups of three words(tricolons)

AI commonly outputs lists of exactly three words, be it three adjectives, three phrases or three clauses. It uses these groups of three words a lot more compared to human-written text.

AI-STYLE

The software is fast, reliable, and easy to use. It helps teams plan, build, and deliver with confidence, making work simpler, smarter, and more efficient.

HUMAN-STYLE

The new software our team is launching this week is quite easy to use. It helps streamline one's everyday tasks and improve efficiency at work. Our internal team's productivity doubled after using this software. Hence, we decided to roll it out for our customers.

2c · "It's not just X, it's Y"

A common way of writing is to put two opposite ideas together to make the sentence sound deep or important. This is also known as negative parallelism. Some of the forms of negative parallelism are "not just X but also Y," "not X but Y," and "X rather than Y." Using it once is fine. But using it repeatedly is a sign of AI writing.

AI-STYLE

This isn't just a phone — it's a companion. It's not merely about features; it's about how they make you feel. This is more than technology — it's a lifestyle.

HUMAN-STYLE

This phone has quite a lot of features compared to similar phones in its price segment. It also has multiple features designed with visually impaired people in mind, which justify the high sales the company has been experiencing.

2d · a word + "-ing" to show significance of something

Look towards the end of sentences, as AI often adds an "-ing" phrase at the end to tell about why something is important. That sentence will be vague without adding any specific or useful information. This is a sign of AI writing, especially when the sentence says that a fact or other non-living thing is "highlighting," "reflecting," "showcasing," or "ensuring" something, even though a fact cannot actually highlight anything.

Look for these PHRASES: "..., highlighting its importance." "..., reflecting broader trends." "..., showcasing its versatility." "..., ensuring lasting impact." "..., emphasising the need for..." "..., paving the way for..."

AI-STYLE

The bridge opened in 1932, highlighting the region's engineering ambition and reflecting a broader shift toward modern infrastructure.

HUMAN-STYLE

This rail-cum-road bridge was inaugurated by the local viceroy in 1932. It has been talked about since then because of the engineering involved, which was quite ahead of its time. It's standing strong even though many decades have passed.

2e · Covering “from X to Y” ranges

AI often writes in a way that makes the topic seem broader than it actually is by combining two unrelated things as though they were opposite ends of a range. It gives us the impression that the sentence covers everything in between those opposite ends.

AI-STYLE

From bustling cities to quiet villages, and from ancient traditions to modern innovation, the country offers something for everyone.

HUMAN-STYLE

India's population is evenly distributed between villages and Cities. Villages are known for their ancient traditions. Cities are leading in terms of innovation. This allows people to pursue their interests, whether by contributing to modern technology or reviving ancient traditions.

3 Substance: what's actually being said

Now, looking beyond the style, AI text is mostly very hollow. It sounds very confident and fluent, but it doesn't contain specific, verifiable details found in human-written text. AI-written text also feels less original and often contains vague information.

3a · Vague sources and claims

AI sometimes refers to sources that appear to exist, but might not actually exist. Instead of giving a source name (like an article by *The Chronicle Times*), it might give a category/type (studies have shown). Although no study might have actually shown it, AI might claim that some studies have shown it without specifying which study. For example: “According to recent academic studies...” when no actual study may even exist. “Studies show.” Which studies? “Experts agree.” Which experts? Real writing includes specific names, dates, and numbers.

Look for these phrases: “studies have shown”, “experts believe”, “many people argue”, “it is widely regarded”, “research suggests”, “some critics say”, “observers have noted”, “a recent study found” (with no citation to specific names, dates and numbers)

AI-STYLE

Studies have shown that music improves focus, and many experts believe it can boost productivity. It is widely regarded as a powerful tool for the modern workplace.

HUMAN-STYLE

The article published in *The Chronicle Times* discusses how music can improve focus. The experiment conducted by the Institute for Neurology, in which 7 out of 10 people showed increased focus, also supports this claim.

QUICK CHECK

We can try to fact-check a claim to see if it's actually true. If all the facts in the passage/paragraph dissolve into some studies / many people argue / experts believe / studies with no name, date, or number attached, then we can consider it as a sign of AI-writing.

3b · Over-explaining obvious things

AI is trained to be thorough and helpful, so its text might include things that a reader already knows. AI also keeps restating its own points in slightly different words.

AI-STYLE

Breakfast is the first meal of the day, eaten in the morning.

Because it is eaten in the morning, it happens earlier than other meals such as lunch or dinner, which come later in the day.

HUMAN-STYLE

Breakfast is usually the first meal of the day for people in India. The elders here often emphasize the importance of breakfast and how it provides the energy needed for everyday hustle.

3c · Having a Conclusion

AI often adds a summary/conclusion at the end, even when the text is already very short and does not need one. It tends to repeat the content of the passage in the conclusion.

Phrases to look for: “In conclusion”, “Overall”, “In summary”, “To sum up”, “Ultimately”, “All in all” — especially in a short piece of text that doesn't need a conclusion

AI-STYLE

In conclusion, this review shows the transformative potential of fiction-based research and offers useful tools for scholars in organization studies and other fields who want to explore this method.

HUMAN-STYLE

This review focuses on organization and management studies, but aims to be of use to other researchers who wish to learn more about recent developments in fiction-based research and search for tools to experiment with this innovative method.

3d · Generic details & default names

AI often chooses very common names when it needs to mention a person, place, or company. It tends to use the same small group of names repeatedly. AI-written articles often use "Emily" or "Sarah" when naming a person. In the example below, we can see how AI is using "small town" to describe a place and "a leading company" to describe a company.

AI-STYLE

Sarah, a local resident, said the small town had changed. A leading company had opened a state-of-the-art facility in the area.

HUMAN-STYLE

My neighbour Pavan has been living here for a decade. He says that Hebbal has undergone a major transformation recently, with many malls, such as Lulu Mall, coming up in the last year or so.

3e · Quotes sounding just like the rest of the article

In AI-written articles, quotes often sound just like the rest of the article. Different people tend to speak

in the same smooth and formal way, and quotes are often placed at the end of a paragraph. Another small sign of AI-writing: humans mostly write “said”, while AI uses *notes*, *explains*, *emphasizes*, *states*

AI-STYLE

“This project represents a pivotal step forward for our community,” **noted** Sarah, **emphasizing** the initiative’s importance. “It is a testament to what we can achieve together.”

HUMAN-STYLE

“The whole community came forward to make the cleaning drive a huge success. This is what we can achieve if everyone comes together in such initiatives,” she said.

4 Tone & voice

We can also spot AI text by its *attitude*: it is very neutral, balanced, and never has a real stake in anything.

4a · AI has no lived experience of anything

AI has no lived experiences to look up to, so it can’t offer the specific details that come from actually being there, like the smell of a place, etc. We can see this in the example below. The AI-written text describes the museum in a very general way, without mentioning anything specific. In contrast, the human-written text refers to specific parts of the museum, such as the Brachiosaurus skeleton and the traditional art floor.

AI-STYLE

Visiting the museum was a wonderful experience. There were many fascinating exhibits, and the atmosphere was pleasant. It is a great destination for people of all ages.

HUMAN-STYLE

The skeleton of the Brachiosaurus is the thing to watch out for in the recently opened museum. Traditional art floor depicting local culture is also worth watching out for.

4b · Excessive hedging & false balance

Excessive hedging means using too many cautious words instead of making a clear statement, and false balance means to present two sides as equally valid or important even when the writer does not actually need to treat them equally. AI is trained to avoid offense, so it writes without taking a side, whereas a human might just take a side.

AI-STYLE

While some people enjoy spicy food, **others may prefer** milder flavours. **Ultimately, it depends on** individual preference, and **there is no right or wrong answer**.

HUMAN-STYLE

This restaurant adds a lot of spices to its food. It’s definitely not for people who can’t handle spicy food; they might want to explore some other restaurant.

4c · AI doesn’t tell us why something is important

AI often tells us that something is very important without explaining why. It uses words like “significant,” “crucial,” “essential,” or “cannot be overstated” without giving specific evidence or examples on why it is important. In the below example, the AI version says communication is “crucial” and “essential,” but it does not show any real example/reason for it to be “crucial” and “essential,” whereas

the human version gives a specific experience, i.e., a person has been suspended due to a lack of proper communication.

AI-STYLE

The importance of communication cannot be overstated. It plays a crucial role in every relationship and is essential for success in all areas of life.

HUMAN-STYLE

My friend has been suspended from the institute for a week after a miscommunication with the administration about using a motorcycle on campus.

5 Formatting clues

These clues (5a and 5b) are especially useful when they appear in informal writing, such as personal messages, casual emails, or social media posts, where a human would not use that kind of formatting. 5c is a useful clue for spotting AI-written content in formal/professional writing. AI also doesn't tend to use brackets, semicolons (;), and ellipsis/dots (...)

5a · Unnecessary formatting

AI often uses **bold** text and bullet points. AI writes in this way, even when a simple paragraph would have been enough. This type of formatting is much more common in AI-written text than in human-written text.

AI-STYLE

Sure! Here are some tips for your trip:

- **Pack light:** Bring only the essentials.
- **Stay hydrated:** Carry a water bottle.
- **Plan ahead:** Book tickets early. — *AI used bold text and bullet points here instead of a simple paragraph.*

HUMAN-STYLE

You need not pack a lot for a 2-day trip. You should book the tickets at least 30 days before the trip. The place is quite hot and humid, so remember to stay hydrated throughout the trip.

5b · The em dash — we need to be careful with this sign

AI uses em dashes (—) a lot, i.e., long dashes. But this is an overrated sign, as many expert human writers also use this em dash. The use of em dashes has declined in AI-written text in recent times, so we shouldn't rely on em dashes alone.

AI-STYLE

LAKEWOOD — A Toms River man was arrested on drug distribution and drunken driving charges after a traffic stop in Lakewood, police said.

HUMAN-STYLE (also uses em dashes)

That makes each and every one of our ebook files not just free, but libre too—because the world deserves more unrestricted culture.

5c · Symbols & emoji

Check-marks (✓), arrows (→), and emojis are signs of AI writing, especially in professional writing.

6 Example Passage

We can see many signs of AI-written text in the paragraph below.

AI-STYLE

In today's fast-paced world, small businesses are more important than ever. Nestled in the heart of the community, these vibrant shops boast a rich tapestry of local character. Studies have shown they play a crucial role in the economy, fostering connection and driving growth. In conclusion, they are not just businesses — they are the beating heart of our towns.

Sentence 1: common opener + importance inflation. Sentence 2: promotional words (*nestled*, *vibrant*, *boast*) + AI vocabulary (*rich tapestry*). Sentence 3: vague sources (*studies have shown*) + giving importance (*crucial role*) + word+“-ing” at the end of sentence to show significance(*fostering*, *driving*) Sentence 4: Has conclusion (*in conclusion*) + “not just X, they are Y”. These are all signs of AI-writing.

HUMAN-STYLE

The supermarket at the end of our street meets many people's everyday needs. It has been the go-to place for people in our colony, despite the rise of quick-commerce platforms, because of the quality of the goods it offers.

§ Sources

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